

The Price of Knowledge

[The Data](#)[Timeline](#)[Ideas](#)[EdTech Graveyard](#)

The EdTech Graveyard

Billions spent. Promises broken. A history of education technology that was supposed to change everything — and what we can learn from each failure.

\$30B+

Spent on MOOCs, adaptive learning, & edtech startups (2010–2023)

5–15%

Average MOOC completion rate

\$36B

Federal aid to for-profit colleges that defrauded students

0

Technologies that replaced the lecture hall

Every decade, a new technology promises to revolutionize education. Radio. Television. Personal computers. The internet. MOOCs. AI. The pattern is always the same: hype, investment, disappointment. But the failures aren't random — they share common DNA. Understanding *why* each technology failed is the key to understanding what might finally succeed.

Ten Failures

Click each one to expand the full analysis: what was promised, what happened, the data, and the lesson for AI-era education.

▼ Expand All

▲ Collapse All

What's **Different** Now?

Every previous edtech revolution failed for the same reasons. AI addresses all of them — for the first time.

The Caveats

History teaches humility. Here's what could still go wrong.

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Sources: MIT/Harvard MOOC studies, RAND Corporation, NBER, Pashler et al. (2008), Bloom (1984), IDB Peru
OLPC study, Duolingo research, NAEP data

Statistics compiled by [Max Song](#) and [Abundance Education](#)